

THE ARTISTS
IN VIENNA

A skeletal auto-rickshaw, a victim of the Mumbai riots. A local superhero who will solve urban problems. A golden door that leads to a mysterious future. Indian art is alive, well and currently showing in Vienna.



On the EDGE

By Kaveree Bamzai |

Art is alive in Vienna. It's on mementos bearing Gustav Klimt's famous kiss. It's in museums such as the Kunsthistorisches where Bruegels compete for attention with the Rubens and the Museum für Angewandte Kunst where 60 of the 200 Hamzanama miniatures survive. And till November 1, art is alive in Chalo India, an exhibition of 27 contemporary artists from India, at the Essl Museum in the Baroque city by the Danube. From 35-year-old Jitish Kallat's trenchant political statement, embodied in a coin which reflects two visions of post-liberalisation India, to 42-year-old Ashim Purkayastha's inversion of Mahatma Gandhi on rupee notes, the exhibition was as

vital as it was controversial. From Gulamohammed Sheikh's *Speaking Tree from Kaavad: The Travelling Shrine*, which tells the story of the coexistence between Hindus and Muslims, to 43-year-old Tushar Joag's *Unicell Man* who provides witty but fake solutions to the problems of Mumbaikars, from its furious floods and its terrible traffic, to 45-year-old Subodh Gupta's enigmatic *Golden Door*, the story of Indian art was as astounding for visitors to Karlheinz Essl's 10-year-old 7,000-work-strong private museum as is the story of India's democracy. As Sheikh puts it so eloquently, "There is no monolithic modernity in India. We live in a multiple world where people speak the language of the 21st century but also live in the 19th century."

Which is why everything the

artists are doing is political, a challenge to the times they live in. Austria, with its own problematic grappling with its past, approaches its past rather less openly. Vienna's first memorial against "war and fascism" was erected only in 1988 and Rachel Whiteread's Nameless Library, a stunning 2000 memorial to the torching of a medieval synagogue, continues to be debated. Yet Indian art has found a way to deal with its conflicts. Like 36-year-old Reena Saini Kallat's deceptively simple portraits of ordinary people composed of rubber stamps, their names scattered all over the parqueted floor of the Essl Museum. Or 39-year-old Jagannath Panda's *Water-05*, a comment on imperfect urbanisation where people gather outside a mansion with a swimming pool to receive